

The Stock Exchange

W. W. Fowler

The tide of humanity that pours down Broadway, is dashed against the bulwarks of Wall Street, and whirled to the eastward, between the mighty walls of granite and sandstone, which line that renowned thoroughfare. Through two mouths, New Street and Broad Street, it is sucked into that seething, whirling, roaring maelstrom—the stock-market. Speaking in the language of the common-place, these two streets are merely avenues in the lower part of the city for the passage of men and loaded wains, and for the transaction of business; but these streets also form the environs of the Stock Exchange, which, as from the focus of a gigantic parabolic reflector, throws a light, more or less lurid, over the whole financial community. That lofty façade on Broad Street, builded as of snowy marble of Paros, “of kingliest masonry,” sinks into a modest, two-story brick rear on New Street, emblematical of the stately fortunes which enter that stately front, and issue diminished from that diminished rear.

This is our palace of Aladdin. Here may be found that wonderful lamp which gives speedy and fabulous wealth to him who grasps it. Here also is stabled that remarkable horse, which, on being mounted, often flies away and leaves its rider on a certain desolate island, called Ruin.